on the outcome of pregnancy. Lactation failure is also common. Teenage mothers fail to breast feed their infants adequately resulting in high infant morbidity rate. Good nutrition and fostering healthy eating habits during adolescence paves way for a healthy adulthood.

3.5.8 Changes in eating habits during adolescence

During adolescence, food habits change for the worse, and teenagers often miss out on the nutrients they need. They begin to skip breakfast; choose less milk, fruits and vegetables and consume more soft drinks each day. Skipping breakfast and eating fast foods contributes to weight gain and higher BMI values. Peer pressure is very high during adolescence. The need to be in step with the trends and belong to the peer group leads the adolescent to eating non-nutritious foods like pizzas, burgers, coffees, aerated drinks, chocolates and also other roadside junk foods which are nutritionally inadequate and rich in saturated fats and may skip meals at times.



Awareness about one's body and its appearance becomes the top priority. It is important for adolescents to realize that they are going through growth spurt and poor nutrition can lead to deficiencies which may cause metabolic disorders in adulthood.

Psychological pressures on adolescents' influence their eating habits. Boys generally tend to have a better appetite than girls and this helps them to meet their nutritional demands. The adolescent girls are at a disadvantage due to the following reasons.

1. with considerable amount of fat deposits and less physical activity than boys, girls may gain weight.

2. figure consciousness due to social pressure may force her into a self-imposed crash diet for weight loss or self-starvation leading to eating disorders like bulimia and anorexia nervosa.

Hence adolescents should be educated to consume a balanced nutritional diet including iron rich, calcium rich, and protein rich foods and avoiding junk foods providing empty calories. The adolescents should be advised not to miss meals and that emotions should not dominate during meal times.

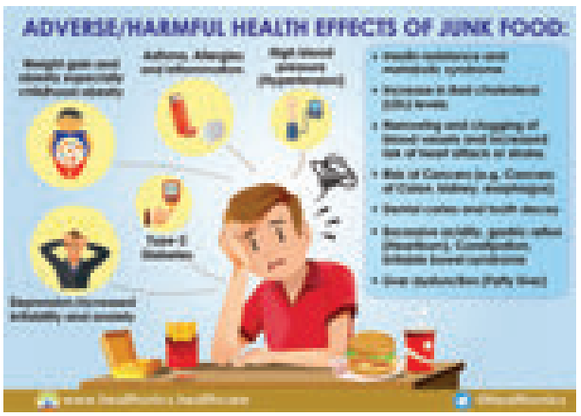


Fig. 3.9 Harmful health effects of junk foods

3.5.9 Dietary guidelines for adolescents

- Adolescence is the time to inculcate food and exercise habits which ensure good health forever. There are simple methods of taking care of health during this period.
- Eat at least two to three meals of fruits in a day for a glowing complexion and to keep constipation away.

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